

Contracting for learning

Learning can be part of a consulting agreement when it is connected to a live decision, usable evidence, and the ability to act. This note develops a question left open in the 30 September 2026 systemic consulting session. It is a proposed approach to test, not an account of a method agreed by the group.

S1 Define what the contract is buying

'We will learn together' is too loose on its own. It can conceal missing purpose or accountability. Promising a solution before inquiry starts can be equally misleading. Ask what the client will be better able to notice, judge, decide, or do, and what evidence would support that claim.

Element	What to agree or examine
Work and outputs	Questions, access, participation, inquiry activities, records, reviews, and a decision process.
Learning	Changes in understanding or judgement, with an account of what changed, why, and what difference it makes.
Capability and practice	Evidence that the client can repeat the inquiry or change a routine without depending on the consultant.
Wider outcomes	Effects on the service or people affected, examined over time with attention to other influences and unequal effects.

Commit to the inquiry and its quality

You can commit to disciplined work and usable evidence. You can agree conditions that support learning. You cannot guarantee that people will change their understanding or that a short assignment will cause a complex public outcome. Make that distinction explicit without abandoning ambition.

Accept unwelcome findings

An informed decision not to proceed can be a useful result. Acceptance should concern the agreed work and the quality of the evidence, including disconfirming evidence. It should not depend on the client receiving the answer they hoped for.

S2 Build a bounded learning agreement

Agree	Make it concrete
Purpose and decision	The question, why it matters, the decision it informs, and who has authority.
Starting account	Current explanations, evidence, assumptions, disagreements, and gaps.
Participation	Who contributes, including people affected; access, time, and permission to surface inconvenient information.
Evidence and method	A proportionate mix of observation, information, conversations, and bounded tests; what could challenge the starting account.
Responsibilities	The consultant's contribution and limits; the client's access, decisions, resources, and follow-through.
Reviews	Dates and authority to continue, adapt, extend, stop, or transfer.
Boundaries	Time and cost limits, constraints on tests, information handling, and scope-change arrangements.
Transfer	Who maintains the learning routine and how its continued use will be observed.

Possible scope wording

'The purpose of this phase is to enable [decision owner] to decide [live question] on a better-evidenced basis. We will jointly examine [questions], test [assumptions], and record evidence, disagreements, and uncertainty. The consultant will provide [contribution]. The client will provide [access, participation, authority, and resources]. At [review dates], we will decide whether to continue, adapt, stop, or agree a further phase. Acceptance concerns the quality and completeness of the agreed work, including evidence that challenges the starting proposal; it does not require a predetermined finding.'

Adapt this practice wording with the client and the organisation's contracting requirements. It is not a ready-made legal clause.

S3 Try it on a six-week inquiry

Illustrative case

A public-service team believes repeated hand-offs delay help. It needs to decide whether to change a referral rule. Staff disagree about the causes, and people using the service experience the hand-offs differently. This is a constructed example, not a reported engagement.

Stage	Work and review
Before starting	Name the decision owner, protect time, agree information use, record the starting explanations and a small baseline. Confirm access and authority.
Weeks 1–2	Trace a bounded set of journeys with staff and people affected, including cases that worked well. Record alternative explanations and sampling limits. Choose a test or further inquiry.
Weeks 3–4	Try a reversible change within agreed authority and safeguards. Notice workload shifts, exclusions, and unexpected effects. Continue, adjust, or stop at review.
Weeks 5–6	Compare the evidence with the starting account. Let the team lead the review. Record the decision, remaining uncertainty, and the next owner and review date.

What would show learning

A changed explanation cites the evidence and its implications. A changed decision shows how the evidence affected a choice. A changed practice is observed in use. Retained capability appears when the client leads another inquiry without consultant prompting. Attendance, satisfaction, and a list of lessons are insufficient on their own.

What the contract delivers

A starting account, an evidence and assumptions record, an authorised bounded test where appropriate, interim reviews, a final decision record, and a transfer exercise. More useful and timely help is the hoped-for wider outcome; six weeks cannot establish or attribute it on its own.

A useful next conversation

Keep a live brief's useful output. Add one learning question, one decision, one way of testing the starting account, and one review where changing direction is allowed. Ask the client what would make that agreement credible.

Related reading

The Transformative Innovation Policy Consortium's formative evaluation approach connects learning objectives and revisable theories of change. Its innovation-policy context is broader than this consulting note. See Molas-Gallart, Boni, Giachi, and Schot (2021), A formative approach to the evaluation of Transformative Innovation Policies, and the linked methodology in the online guide.